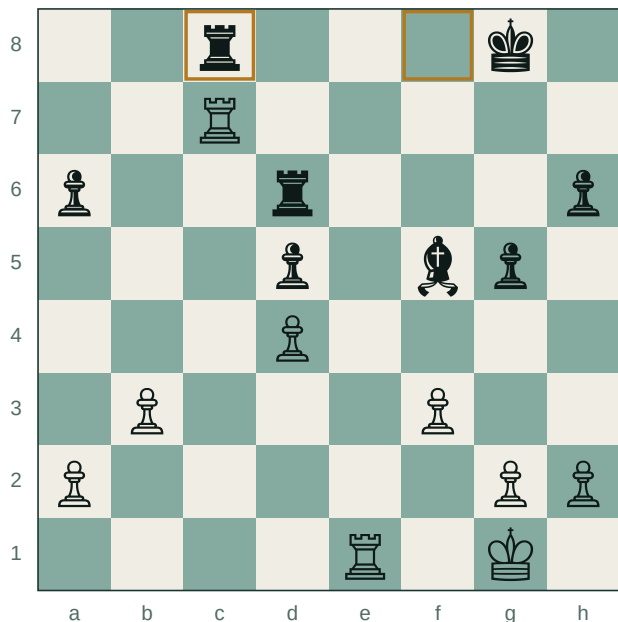


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 26

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 25...Rc8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Rxc8+ Bxc8 27. Re8+ Kg7 28. Rxc8

26.Rxc8+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on c8. Recorded reply: **26...Bxc8**.

27.Re8+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From e8 it attacks king on g8 and bishop on c8. Recorded reply: **27...Kg7**.

28.Rxc8 The rook captures the bishop on c8.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 9 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on d6 and bishop on f5. Check for tactical protection.